GREAT EXPECTATIONS

VIKRAM VEDHA

Sept. 30

A remake of the hit Tamil action drama starring Vijay Sethupathi and R. Madhavan, its Hindi version sees Hrithik Roshan and Saif Ali Khan in a face-off. With the original creators, Pushkar-Gayathri, at the helm, a faithful recreation is expected.





RAM SETU

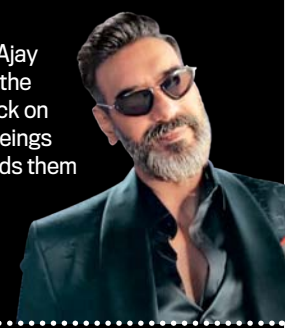
Oct 24

With three flops, Akshay Kumar has thus far had a year to forget. Could fourth time be a charm? This action adventure, also featuring Nushrratt Bharuccha and Jacqueline Fernandez, sees Kumar play an archaeologist who sets out to discover whether the eponymous "bridge" is myth or reality.

THANK GOD

Oct. 24

This comedy features Ajay Devgn as Chitragupta, the deity who keeps a check on the actions of human beings and punishes or rewards them accordingly. Sidharth Malhotra faces the ultimate test to get a second shot at life.



AVATAR: THE WAY OF WATER

Dec 16



In the visionary James Cameron, we trust. The *Titanic* filmmaker returns after 12 years with part two of the epic fantasy action series. Cinemas are betting big on this one. They are sure it will beat collections of the first instalment to become the highest-grossing film of all time.

CIRKUS

Dec 23

Bet against Rohit Shetty at your own peril. Currently one of the most prolific and successful Hindi filmmakers, he returns to the comedy genre and teams up with his *Simmba* hero Ranveer Singh for what he calls a "different take" on Shakespeare's *The Comedy of Errors*.



success, says Gautam Dutta, CEO of PVR Cinemas. "Consumers are saying: 'You give me good content, and I care two hoots about what people are saying.' Show me one film where the reviews and word-of-mouth is positive and the film didn't do well!" says Dutta. Our single-minded obsession with failures seems to negate one key fact: in pre-pandemic times, for every 1,000+ releases a year, the success ratio was only 20-25 per cent. Not all films are blockbusters. Most hardly make a dent. That trend continues. There is just one change: As audiences can catch the films on OTT later, they seem more drawn towards films that deliver on big screen entertainment and can become outings for the entire family.

Dutta thinks it's wrong to write off Bollywood for its misses; one needs to also account for the handful of hits the industry has delivered this year—*Gangubai Kathiwadi*, *The Kashmir Files* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*. "If the Zara autumn or summer collection didn't do well, do you sign off of the brand? Our product changes every Friday. We need to see the few weeks and months as aberrations and move on," he says.

With the festive season around the corner, cinemas now have their hopes pinned on a spate of big-ticket releases. Everyone from Akshay Kumar (*Ram Setu*) to Ranveer Singh (*Cirkus*) will be hoping to ensure that 2022 ends on an uplifting note for an industry that has taken its time to show signs of recovery. Meanwhile, as social media trends go, boycott calls began again after the trailer of Diwali release *Thank God* hit YouTube. Trolls were seen taking offence to the depiction of Chitragupta, played by Ajay Devgn (see *Great Expectations*) in the comedy. It remains to be seen if these calls will be successful, but if *Brahmastra*'s showing is anything to go by, a film's ultimate fate is in the hands of audiences, not trolls who are only to quick to take umbrage. ■

–Suhani Singh